What We Know, What We're Assuming, What We'd Ask

A family worksheet for the areas a professional may look at.

“The house is in Mom's name” and “I think the house is in Mom's name” are different sentences. A professional can work with either one, as long as they can tell which it is.

For each area below, write three things: what you know, with the paper or the person behind it; what you're assuming; and what you'd ask, and whom. Fill it in over a few weeks, not in one sitting.

If you don't know, write “don't know” and leave it. Nothing on this page needs fixing.

Mom's day-to-day care

How she is managing now: what she does on her own, where someone helps, what her doctor has said. Only what someone has seen or been told.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: she cooks, drives to the store and keeps her own calendar. Karen was there last week. Assuming: she's keeping up with her pills; nobody has looked. Ask: her doctor, at the next check-up.

Income and assets

What comes in each month and what she has: accounts, policies, anything else. Round numbers are enough, and “not sure” is a fine answer.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: Social Security and a pension from the school district; both show on her bank statement. Assuming: there's one savings account, and a life insurance policy from years ago. Haven't seen either. Ask: Mom, where the papers are.

Her home, other property, and anything that has changed hands

The house, a car, land, and anything given away, sold or put in someone else's name, as far as the family remembers. Write what happened and roughly when. Don't decide what it means.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: the house, and one car. Assuming: the deed is in her name alone; nobody has seen it in years. Know: she helped a grandchild with tuition some time back; no one remembers the year. Ask: your Medicaid planner, what they'd want to know about either one.

Documents and legal authority

The legal documents you know exist and where they are, and who would be able to act for Mom if she couldn't. Whether a document does what the family thinks it does is an attorney's question.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: there's a will, signed years ago, in the desk. Assuming: David can sign for her at the bank because he helps with her bills. Ask: an elder law attorney, what would need to be in place.

Family

Who is involved, who lives near, who hasn't been asked yet, and anything the family sees differently.

FOR EXAMPLE Know: Karen lives closest and would notice a change first. Assuming: everyone agrees Mom would stay in the house. We haven't asked David, or Mom. Ask: each other, with Mom in the room.

Who filled this in, and when

What this shows you

For each area: what your family knows, what you've been taking for granted, and what you'd ask, with a name beside each question. It doesn't show whether anything here is a concern or stands in the way of anything. That is a professional's judgment, it depends on where Mom lives, and nothing on this page adds up to a score or a result. Nothing here is legal, financial or tax advice; those questions go to your Medicaid planner or the appropriate licensed professional.

Ready for the next step?

You've sorted what you know from what you were assuming, one area at a time. The planning interview picks up from there: it asks about your family's situation and gives you a free planning report you can bring to any conversation about paying for Mom's care.

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